Rahul Gandhi is not Mahatma Gandhi, and he is the first to deny any comparison. And yet, there is something in the message of Rahul Gandhi's Bharat Jodo Yatra of the freshness that Nehru recounts about the advent of Gandhi. Looking around at the generally self-seeking, sectarian and even venal nature of politics, Rahul Gandhi's slogan 'Do Not Be Afraid' struck a new chord. It was also akin to Gandhi ji's call to shed fear. The act of carrying out the Yatra was itself a demonstration of fearlessness. In a situation where almost no street protests were being allowed, to walk on the streets for almost 4,000 kilometres over a period of more than four months, accompanied by thousands and sometimes lakhs of people, was an act of daring. It also somewhere showed the powerlessness of the authorities when faced with huge numbers of people showing their support. Even though in the beginning there was a lot of speculation about the BJP governments stopping the Yatra, as time passed and the Yatra drew out more and more people into the open, and their enthusiasm and support became palpable, it became more and more difficult for the governments in question to obstruct it.

The BJY comes across as a massive mass-contact programme of the kind we are familiar with in the annals of our freedom struggle, but which we have lost in the marketplace of power politics. The BJY's focus on communal harmony, love, social and economic justice, and against inequality and crony capitalism, are also evocative of a politics based on ideals and not motivated by an overwhelming hankering for the loaves and fishes of office. It is this freshness and idealism that proved to be the Pied Piper that pulled young and old, men and women, abled and disabled, out of their cloisters. The sheer diversity of those who lined the streets and joined the march, for short distances and long, was mind-boggling. Schoolchildren joined and played football with Rahul, young dancers performed while walking along, disabled ex-servicemen came on their wheelchairs, nurses and doctors and lawyers, factory workers and landowning and landless agricultural workers, fisherfolk, handloom workers, homemakers, scholars from India and abroad, writers, journalists, filmmakers, stand-up comedians, film stars, social activists who worked with the disadvantaged,